

to adopt technologies that are new and will last for the next seven to ten years, and hyper-convergence tops that list.

Just four years back, we were struggling to explain the benefits of hyper-convergence to customers. But starting this year, we have noticed that they have educated themselves fairly well on the topic and are approaching us for solutions around hyper-convergence.

Q What does Dell EMC offer in the area of hyper-convergence?

Dell EMC's hyper-convergence solution has two key offerings. One is our appliance based offering, known as VxRail and the other is our rack based offering called VxRack. Both these categories come in two flavours – a VMware based flavour wherein the end-to-end solution is based on the VMware software stack, and the mixed hypervisor option wherein the customers have the flexibility to choose the kind of hypervisor that they want to deploy.

The reason for having two different flavours is primarily because a big chunk of the market is tilted towards VMware hyper-converged solutions; hence, we have an offering dedicated for VMware. Also, there is a set of customers who would want to have flexibility, which is why we provide the second flavour as well.

Q Why do you have two options – application based and rack based?

When customers want to start small and are looking at deploying hyper-convergence solutions in small standalone remote offices, branch offices and business units, or when they want to just test hyper-convergence, they may choose appliance based offerings, whereby they can buy two or three nodes to start with and

experience hyper-convergence in their environment. These customers tend not to have sufficient tech staff to manage infrastructure, are facing support issues or want to be up within a faster time frame.

Customers who have already tasted success with hyper-convergence and want to deploy it in multiple branches, business units or applications, and want a highly scalable environment, opt for rack based offerings. They can start with four to five nodes and scale up to hundreds of nodes, experiencing hyper-convergence across their entire business environment. These customers want to adopt hyper-convergence on an enterprise scale and consolidate their business units.

“We are looking forward to making software completely automated in the future, with the help of hyper-convergence. However, to achieve this, the technology has to mature to a greater extent.”

Q What are the recent trends in hyper-convergence and in what direction do you see them evolve in the future?

The hyper-converged infrastructure started out with the convergence of only the storage environment. Software defined storage led that initiative. So instead of customers buying physical hardware for storage, they started encouraging the installation of software for storage. Now, convergence has gone beyond storage to compute and the network, and is also encompassing the creation of your own private cloud.

We have an offering called VxRack SDDC, which is powered by VMware software called VMware Cloud Foundation (VCF), for this

purpose. Apart from providing hyper-convergence around storage, compute and network, it also provides customers with self-service portals. On these portals, they can put in their requirements for different business units, which then get automatically provisioned from the system, based on the department's approval.

This is like an artificial intelligence (AI) application built into the system, wherein, without any manual intervention, the resources the department wants get created and delivered, after which a report stating how much of that resource has been used by the relevant department, as well as the cost, is also generated.

IT will become more like a self-serviced division; it will work like an automated arm and create better revenues for that department. However, right now, the customers have just started off in this direction and not all of them are mature enough to adopt it. But hyper-convergence is the future of IT.

Q How are Dell EMC's hyper-convergence solutions unique?

Dell is the only vendor providing end-to-end rack based solutions that integrate the network as well. We also have a management console taking care of not just the compute, memory and network but also of solutions that are entirely software defined — like self-servicing, charge back and automation. Therein lies Dell's uniqueness.

With VMware being a part of Dell EMC, we are the only firm with an appliance based hyper-converge solution that is on VMware, from end-to-end. Jointly, we have created a hyper-convergence solution, and we do not have to rely on multiple technologies to move forward on our hyper-convergence journey.

Ideally, all software should work in tandem with each other and this can happen only when the software is developed as a product from a